The 'column' command in Linux

The *column* command in Linux displays data from the file name given as an argument in a columnar format. The number of columns gets adjusted as per the size of the terminal. The blank lines in the input file are ignored. The left columns are filled first before the right columns, by default.

For example, if a file named 'numbers.txt' contains the numbers 1 to 20, one number per line, the command given below can be used to display the numbers in columns:

```
$column numbers.txt
```

The numbers will be displayed in multiple columns:

```
1    4    7    10   13   16   19
2    5    8    11   14   17   20
3    6    9    12   15   18
```

The number of columns will depend on the size of the terminal.

The display can be from left to right, that is, row first and then the columns if the *-x* option is used.

```
$column -x numbers.txt
```

The output for the above command will be what's shown below:

```
1    2    3    4    5    6    7
8    9    10   11   12   12   14
15   16   17   18   19   20
```

In case the fields in the input file are separated by a delimiter, the *-s* option can be used to specify the delimiter. The default delimiter is whitespace. The *-t* option can be used to get the display in a tabular format. The columns are delimited by whitespace unless the *-o* option is used to specify the delimiter in the output table. You can try the table and the delimiter option on the */etc/passwd* file where ':' is the delimiter and see the effect.

```
$column -s: -t /etc/passwd
```

—Sathyanarayanan S, sathyanarayanan.brn@gmail.com

Emptying a file without deleting it

Many a time, we need to empty the contents of a file without deleting the file itself. Here is a simple command that will let you do so. Run the following command in a terminal:

```
$ > file_name
```

This will leave an empty file with the filename used in the command.

— Sai Krishna, settykrishh.93@gmail.com

Reusing the last command

To reuse an already executed command on a Linux terminal, use '!!' (double exclamation) along with the current command. This calls the entire previous command.

Here is an example:

```
$sudo apt-get install python3
error : lock is not available.

$ sudo !!
```

This will automatically replace '!!' with the last command and then execute it.

We can also reuse part of the command by using '!$' with our command.

For example:

```
$ ls /krishna
```

Now execute the following command:

```
$ cd !$

!$ will replace /krishna.
```

—Sai Krishna, settykrishh.93@gmail.com

Finding any file or folder in user-authorised directories

By using the 'locate' command in UNIX-like operating systems, you can easily find files and folders.

For example:

```
$locate Downloads
```

The above command will give you the complete path of the *Downloads* folder, if it exists.

```
$locate filename.txt
```

The above command will give you the complete path to the *filename.txt* file, if it exists.

—Umang Parmar, umangjparmar@gmail.com

END

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